A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Jude 1–2

Standing in the Storm: Grace, Mercy, and Peace

Small Group Bible Study Series · Jude

Source: The Gospel Vault

Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NASB · Jude 1–2

1 *Jude, a bond-servant of Jesus Christ, and brother of James, To those who are the called, beloved in God the Father, and kept for Jesus Christ:*

2 *May mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"To those who are the called, beloved in God the Father, and kept for Jesus Christ: May mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you."*

Before Jude says a single word about the storm, he tells you who you are in it. Called. Beloved. Kept. Those three words are not a warm-up to the important part of the letter. They are the ground that the rest of the letter stands on.

The word “kept” carries the most weight. It describes something God has done to you and is still doing: you are being held for Jesus Christ. Not by your own grip, but by His.

And into that held, secure life Jude prays three gifts — mercy, peace, and love — multiplied. Not rationed. Overflowing. Before you face whatever this week brings, let these two verses speak first: you are kept, and you are prayed for.

Reflect

1. When difficulty comes, do you respond from the security of being kept, or from the anxiety of trying to keep yourself?
2. Which of the three gifts — mercy, peace, or love — do you most need to receive as multiplied right now?
3. How does it change the way you read this letter to know that Jude began it with a prayer for his readers?

You are not entering the storm unprotected. You are entering it kept.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Before Jude says one word about the danger, he tells his readers who they are — called, beloved, and kept for Jesus Christ — and prays that mercy, peace, and love would overflow in them.

Introduction — Twenty-Four Words That Change Everything

Jude's first two verses run to only twenty-four words in Greek, and in that space he tells us who he is, who his readers are, and what he wants God to do for them — all before he says one word about the danger that fills the rest of the letter. That order is a pastoral strategy. Before you tell people what they are up against, you remind them who they are.

We usually do the opposite. We lead with the crisis and build our identity around what we are against. Jude begins with identity secured in God, and only then turns to the storm. These two verses are the calm that makes the rest of the letter bearable.

In verse 3 Jude will tell us that he meant to write a different letter, one about "our common salvation," and was forced by events to write this one. Both impulses come from the same love. The man who wanted to celebrate the gospel was compelled to defend it, because you cannot love something and shrug when it is under attack. A church that only celebrates the gospel will eventually lose what it was celebrating. A church that only defends it becomes a company of watchmen who forget what they are guarding. Jude holds both, and the opening verses show which comes first.

I. The Author: A Servant Who Knew Better – v. 1a

A. A slave, not a celebrity

Jude introduces himself two ways: "a bond-servant of Jesus Christ" and "brother of James." The second needed no explanation. James led the church in Jerusalem (Acts 15:13; Galatians 2:9), and everyone knew that James and Jude were half-brothers of Jesus (Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3). What Jude leaves unsaid is the loudest thing in the verse: he does not call himself the Lord's brother.

He chooses *doulos* — slave. It is the word Paul uses of himself in Romans 1:1, Peter in 2 Peter 1:1, and James in James 1:1. A slave belongs wholly to another and has no independent claims. Jude held the most impressive family credential in the early church and did not use it. His authority rests on whom he serves, not on whom he grew up beside.

B. A skeptic turned servant

That is more striking given where Jude began. John 7:5 says flatly that "not even His brothers were believing in Him." Jude watched the miracles, heard the teaching, shared the family table — and did not believe. Then the resurrection happened, and by Acts 1:14 the brothers of Jesus are in the upper room praying with the apostles. Jude went from skeptic to slave.

The man writing with the most urgency in this letter was once on the other side of the question. He knows what unbelief feels like from the inside, and he knows what the risen Christ can do with it. Grace does not erase a person's history; it reinterprets it. Jude's family history becomes the backstory of his conversion, not the basis of his authority. That is a good word for any teacher. You are not authorized by your résumé, your family, or your nearness to someone impressive. You are authorized by the One you serve.

In the first-century world a slave had no claims of his own, and the word could sting. Yet in the New Testament, belonging to Christ is the opposite of bondage. Paul can say that the one who was called as a slave is the Lord's freedman (1 Corinthians 7:22) and that being enslaved to God brings fruit and eternal life (Romans 6:22). To be Christ's *doulos* is to be freed from every other master. Jude's title is not a humiliation; it is where his freedom lives.

Think of the boss's son who joins the family firm and, instead of introducing himself at every meeting as the boss's son, simply gives his name and his work. The relationship is real. He just lets his service speak first.

II. The Recipients: Three Words That Hold the World Together – v. 1b

Jude describes his readers with three parallel terms. Each is a theological statement, and together they are among the most compact descriptions of the believer's standing anywhere in the New Testament letters. They are not decoration. They are the foundation of the whole letter.

A. Called

"The called" is the New Testament's ordinary label for believers — people who have answered the gospel and now belong to God (Romans 1:6–7; 1 Corinthians 1:2). It describes something that has already happened to them. It is not a job description or a status they must keep earning. Jude's readers are God's people before they do anything for Him.

B. Beloved in God the Father

Here the manuscripts divide. Some read *hēgiasmenois*, "sanctified"; the NASB follows *ēgapēmenois*, "beloved," the reading most modern editions adopt. The two Greek words look alike, which explains how a copyist could confuse them. Either reading says something true — set apart by God, or loved by God — but "beloved" sets the tone. Believers are not first of all strivers. They are loved ones, and love is the realm they live in. Jude keeps coming back to it: "Beloved" in verses 3, 17, and 20, and "the love of God" in verse 21.

C. Kept for Jesus Christ

The third word is the one Jude will not let go of. *Tetērēmenois*, "kept," is a perfect passive participle. The perfect tense describes a completed action whose results continue into the present. The passive voice means someone else is doing the keeping. Put together: at a past moment these believers were placed in a state of being kept, and that keeping is in force right now as Jude writes. It is the difference between "the door was locked" and "the door has been locked and stays locked."

The believer is not keeping himself in this verse. God is keeping him — continuously, personally, for a purpose. And the purpose is in the phrase “for Jesus Christ.” They are not only kept safely; they are kept *toward* Someone, held for the day they are presented to Him. That is exactly where the letter will end. The same God who is keeping them now is “able to keep you from stumbling” and “to make you stand in the presence of His glory blameless with great joy” (v. 24).

Notice the shape of the verse. The Father’s love, the Son’s keeping, and — as the letter unfolds — the Spirit’s prayer (v. 20) make the whole of verses 1–25 quietly Trinitarian. Believers are “beloved in God the Father,” “kept for Jesus Christ,” and are told to pray “in the Holy Spirit.” The letter closes by turning to “the only God our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord” (v. 25). Whatever else the intruders are doing, they are cutting themselves off from the God who is doing all of this for His people.

Watch the verb as it travels through the letter. God keeps believers (v. 1). He keeps rebellious angels in eternal bonds for judgment (v. 6). Black darkness “has been reserved” for wandering stars (v. 13). Believers are told to “keep yourselves in the love of God” (v. 21). And God is “able to keep you from stumbling” (v. 24). Hold that thread. It is how Jude will answer the question the whole letter raises: what is really holding us?

This is where Free Grace and Reformed readers part ways, so it is worth saying plainly. Reformed theology also teaches that God keeps His people, but it ties that keeping to the perseverance of the saints: the elect will necessarily persevere in faith and holiness, and the warnings of the letter are means God uses to secure that perseverance.[1] The Free Grace reading takes the perfect passive at face value. The keeping is God’s act toward the believer, grounded in His promise and His power, and it does not wait to be confirmed by the believer’s later track record.[2] We will hold that reading through the series and test it against each warning as we meet it.

Picture a valuable work of art held in trust. The trustee does not own it. He guards it, restores it if needed, and protects it from harm — not because the art earns its place, but because it belongs to Someone who is coming for it. The believer is held in trust for Jesus Christ.

III. The Greeting: A Prayer for Overflow – v. 2

A. Mercy, peace, and love — in that order

“May mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you.” The order is not random. Mercy comes first because it is logically first: before there can be peace with God, there must be mercy from God. The breach between the human soul and its Creator is not closed by our improvement; it is closed by the mercy that removes what stood between us. Peace is the fruit of that mercy received (Romans 5:1). And love is the overflow of both — the settled warmth of people who have been shown mercy, have been given peace, and know it.

The triad is distinctive. Paul’s letters to Timothy use “grace, mercy, and peace,” and Peter writes “grace and peace” (1 Peter 1:2; 2 Peter 1:2). Only Jude writes “mercy and peace and love.” It fits a man who grew up in the same house as Jesus and knows what love looks like when it is unreserved and undeserved.

There is also a quiet thread of mercy through the letter. Jude prays for mercy in verse 2. In verse 21 believers are told to wait "for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ," and in verses 22–23 they are told to "have mercy" on others three times. Mercy asked for, mercy awaited, mercy given. The people who have been shown mercy are to become mercy to those in danger. What Jude prays for his readers in verse 2 becomes what he asks them to do for others at the end.

B. Multiplied

The verb *plēthyntheiē* is an optative of wish — a prayer, not a command and not a report. Jude is interceding. Before the first warning, before the first historical example, the writer of this urgent letter stops to pray. The prayer does not imply the gifts are missing; these are people who already have mercy, peace, and love. Jude asks that they be so abundant in the community's daily experience that there is no room left for the anxiety, suspicion, and division that false teaching feeds on. You do not fight a creeping cold by condemning it. You fight it by generating heat. Jude's first answer to a crisis is a prayer for overflow.

For the preacher: sit in these two verses longer than they seem to demand. The temptation is to hurry to verses 3–4, where the action is. But these two verses are the action. A congregation that has truly received the identity of verse 1 and the intercession of verse 2 can face the warnings of verses 3–23 without being undone by them. Skip them, and the congregation faces the rest of the letter without the ground under its feet. A firefighter does not run into the building without suiting up. The gear does not put out the fire, but it lets him go in.

Conclusion

Before the warnings come, before the portraits of false teachers appear, before the battle cry is sounded, God establishes who His people are. They are called. They are beloved. They are kept. The crisis is real, the false teachers are real, and the damage they can do is real. But none of that changes the three descriptions of verse 1. The storm is real — and so is the keeping, and the keeping is more real.

That is how Jude can ask these believers to contend and not ask them to panic. They can fight for the faith because the faith has first been given to them and will not be taken from them. And before he asks them to do anything, he prays: mercy, peace, and love, multiplied. Not grim resolve. Not anxious defensiveness. Overflow.

That is why this study belongs first. Before the series asks you to contend, to discern, to rescue, it asks you to rest in three words: called, beloved, kept. If you can truly hear them, the rest of the letter becomes a letter from a brother who loves you, not a threat from a man who doubts you.

You came today carrying something — a fear, a pressure, a question. Hear what the letter says first: you are called, you are beloved, you are kept for Jesus Christ. Whatever storm is in front of you, you are walking into it as a kept person.

Lord, thank You that we are kept.

Sources and Notes

1. Reformed treatment of perseverance and the warning passages: Thomas R. Schreiner and Ardel B. Caneday, *The Race Set Before Us: A Biblical Theology of Perseverance and Assurance* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2001); see also Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans), on perseverance of the saints.

2. Free Grace treatment of assurance and security: Robert N. Wilkin, *Confident in Christ: Living by Faith Really Works* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 1999); Zane C. Hodges, *Absolutely Free! A Biblical Reply to Lordship Salvation* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1989); Charles C. Bing, *Simply by Grace* (Grand Rapids: Kregel, 2009).

3. Word studies: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entries G1401 (*doulos*), G2822 (*klētos*), G25 (*agapaō*), G5083 (*tēreō*), G1656 (*eleos*), G1515 (*eirēnē*), G26 (*agapē*), G4129 (*plēthynō*); W. Bauer, F. W. Danker et al., *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (BDAG), 3rd ed.

4. The brothers of Jesus: Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; John 7:5; Acts 1:14; 1 Corinthians 9:5; 15:7. Verse-by-verse help: Thomas L. Constable, *Expository Notes on Jude*, planobiblechapel.org/tcon/notes/; NET Bible translators' notes on Jude 1.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.1	**δοῦλος** slave, bond-servant	G1401 doulos N-Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: a slave, bondman. Significance: a title of complete belonging. The same word Paul, Peter, and James use of themselves. Jude leads with surrender, not with his family tie to Jesus.
v.1	**κλητοῖς** called ones	G2822 klētois Adj./N-Dat. Pl. Masc.	STR: called, invited. Significance: the ordinary New Testament name for believers (Rom. 1:6–7; 1 Cor. 1:2) — a description of what has already happened to them.
v.1	**ἠγαπημένοις** beloved	G25 ēgapēmenois Perf. Pass. Ptc. Dat. Pl. Masc.	STR: to love (agapaō). Significance: perfect tense — loved with continuing results. Some manuscripts read *hēgiasmenois* ("sanctified"); the NASB follows "beloved."
v.1	**τετηρημένοις** kept	G5083 tetērēmenois Perf. Pass. Ptc. Dat. Pl. Masc.	STR: to guard, keep. Significance: completed action with ongoing effect, done by another. God is the Keeper. First of the letter's "keeping" words (vv. 1, 6, 13, 21, 24).
v.1	**Ἰησοῦ Χριστῷ** for Jesus Christ	G2424 / G5547 Iēsou Christō N-Dat. Sg. Masc.	Significance: the dative names the One for whom the believers are kept — a destination as well as a protection. It looks ahead to the presentation of v. 24.
v.2	**ἔλεος** mercy	G1656 eleos N-Nom. Sg. Neut.	STR: kindness or good will toward the miserable. Significance: logically first — mercy from God must come before peace with God.
v.2	**εἰρήνη** peace	G1515 eirēnē N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	STR: peace, harmony. Significance: the settled result of mercy received — a restored relationship (Rom. 5:1), not just the absence of anxiety.
v.2	**ἀγάπη** love	G26 agapē N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	STR: love, goodwill. Significance: the only New Testament greeting with this triad. Love is the overflow of mercy and peace, and the "realm" (v. 21) believers live in.
v.2	**πληθυνθείη** be multiplied	G4129 plēthyntheiē Aor. Pass. Opt. 3rd Sg.	STR: to increase, multiply. Significance: an optative of wish — a prayer. Jude intercedes for overflow, not for the first arrival of these gifts.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why does Jude call himself a servant instead of “the Lord’s brother”?	Because his authority rests on whom he serves, not on whom he grew up beside. *Doulos* is a title of belonging, and it fits a man who once did not believe (John 7:5) and was changed by the resurrection.
What three descriptions does Jude give his readers?	Called, beloved in God the Father, and kept for Jesus Christ. They are descriptions of what God has done and loves, not tasks assigned to them.
What do the grammar of “kept” (perfect passive participle) and the phrase “for Jesus Christ” tell us?	Perfect: a completed action still in force. Passive: someone else does the keeping — God. “For Jesus Christ”: the keeping has a destination, the day believers are presented to Him (v. 24).
Why do manuscripts differ over “sanctified” and “beloved,” and does it matter?	The Greek words look alike, so a copyist could confuse them. Both are true of believers. The NASB follows “beloved,” which fits the letter’s repeated use of “beloved” (vv. 3, 17, 20).
What does Jude pray for, and why is the order significant?	Mercy, peace, and love, multiplied. Mercy comes first because peace with God depends on God’s mercy; love is the overflow of both.
Why does Jude open with identity before he mentions any danger?	People can only face a crisis well when they know who they are. A congregation grounded in verse 1 can hear verses 3–23 without panic.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Think of a time you faced a hard season. Did you meet it feeling kept, or feeling alone? What made the difference?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.C — the perfect passive “kept” and the trust image.*

2. Jude had a famous family credential and did not use it. Where are you tempted to lean on a credential — family, church, experience — instead of on Christ?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.A–B — doulos and John 7:5 / Acts 1:14.*

3. What is the difference between being “called” and “beloved” as ways of describing yourself? How would it change your day to start there?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.A–B — the ordinary New Testament use of “the called” and the repeated “beloved” in vv. 3, 17, 20.*

4. How is “kept by God” different from “keeping yourself”? Why might Jude begin with the first?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.C — the keeping thread through vv. 1, 6, 13, 21, 24; Free Grace and Reformed views of perseverance.*

5. Who in your group needs mercy, peace, or love multiplied right now? How could you pray Jude 2 for them this week?

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.A–B — the optative of wish and the order of the three gifts.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
v. 1a	The Author	Identity by surrender, not by origin. Jude is a slave of Jesus Christ who once did not believe.
v. 1b	The Recipients	Believers are called, beloved in God the Father, and actively kept by God for Jesus Christ.
v. 2	The Greeting	Jude prays for mercy, peace, and love to overflow — before a single warning is given.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Lead with Identity, Not with the Threat

Jude 1

Drawn from Commentary Introduction and II. Key terms: klētois (called), tetērēmenois (kept).

Jude spends his first verse on who his readers are before he says a word about what they face. That is wise pastoral order. People can take hard truth when they know they are called, loved, and kept. Without that footing the same truth only produces fear.

Reflection: When you talk to others about a problem — a child, a friend, a church — do you start with the threat or with who they are in Christ?

Practical Step: Before your next hard conversation, name aloud one thing that is true of that person in Christ. Notice how it changes the rest of the conversation.

Application 2 — Live from the Locked Door

Jude 1b

Drawn from Commentary II.C. Key term: tetērēmenois (perfect passive participle). FGR: Wilkin, Confident in Christ.

"Kept" is a perfect passive: God did it, and it stays done. A believer who treats his security as fragile — one bad week from being undone — is living as if the door might be open. Jude invites a different posture: rest in a keeping you did not earn and cannot lose, and then get on with the work of the letter.

Reflection: Do you experience your relationship with God as something you are maintaining, or as something He is maintaining?

Practical Step: For one week, read Jude 1b aloud each morning — "called, beloved, kept for Jesus Christ" — before anything else. Note what changes.

Application 3 — Pray the Multiplication Prayer

Jude 2

Drawn from Commentary III. Key term: plēthyntheiē (be multiplied).

Jude's first answer to a community in danger is a prayer, not a plan. Communities soaked in mercy, peace, and love are very hard to destabilize. You cannot easily pull people away from an overflow.

Reflection: As a group: which of the three gifts is thinnest in your community right now — mercy, peace, or love?

Practical Step: Open your next meeting by praying Jude 2 over each person by name: "[Name], may mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you."

Application 4 — Kept For Someone

Jude 1b; 24

Drawn from Commentary II.C and Conclusion. Cf. Jude 24.

The “for” in “kept for Jesus Christ” names a destination. You are not simply being held in place. You are being held for a Person and a day. The whole letter will end where verse 1 points: presented before His glory with great joy.

Reflection: How would it change your current season to see it as a keeping in progress, aimed at a coming presentation?

Practical Step: Read Jude 1b and Jude 24 together. Write one sentence joining them, and bring it to share.

End of Study · Jude 1–2